Say it right

Spanish is spelled the way it sounds. Learn these and you can read any word aloud. This is the Latin American way.

	sounds like	try it
a e i o u	five short, clean vowels, always the same	casa, mesa, sí, todo, uno
h	silent	hola, ahora
ñ	ny, as in canyon	año, niño
ll, y	y, as in yes (one sound in most of Latin America)	llamo, yo
j; g before e, i	a strong h from the throat	jamón, gente
g before a, o, u	g, as in go	gato, gusto
gue, gui · güe, güi	the u is silent · the u is heard	guitarra · pingüino
c before e, i; z	s (in Latin America)	cena, zapato
c before a, o, u; qu	k	casa, queso
r	one quick tap of the tongue	pero, caro
rr; r at the start or after l, n, s	a rolled r	perro, rojo, Enrique
b, v	the same sound	vaso, beso
x in México, Oaxaca	like j	México

pero
but

perro
dog

caro
expensive

carro
car

Tip: keep every vowel short and clear, even when it is not stressed. English blurs unstressed vowels into “uh”; Spanish never does.

SOURCES

- RAE–ASALE, Ortografía de la lengua española (2010): the letters and the sounds they stand for.
- RAE–ASALE, Diccionario panhispánico de dudas (DPD, 2.ª ed. en línea, rae.es/dpd), entries “seseo”, “yeísmo” and “México”.